

What Makes the Gospel Any Different?

Ricky Alcantar · Cross of Grace Church El Paso, El Paso, TX · October 4, 2026

Series: Romans

Romans 1:1-15 PRIMARY TEXT	52 min SERMON LENGTH	16 SCRIPTURE REFERENCES	36 SECTIONS WE MAPPED
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THE SERMON IN ONE SENTENCE

The Gospel of Jesus Christ is utterly unique in the marketplace of ideas because it offers not adjustment but transformation, not subjective truth but God's objective truth proved in history, not grace after obedience but grace before obedience, and not exclusive victory but invitation to all nations.

Summary

Ricky Alcantar opens his Romans series by arguing that the Gospel of Jesus Christ is utterly unique in a marketplace of ideas where everything else is repackaged sameness. Working through Romans 1:1-7, he develops five contrasts: the Gospel transforms rather than adjusts identity (seen in Paul's radical conversion); it offers God's objective truth rather than subjective opinion; it is rooted in verifiable history—especially the resurrection—not myth; it gives grace before obedience rather than demanding works to earn divine favor; and it invites all nations rather than benefiting one group at another's expense. Using a Guatemalan marketplace illustration and a rock-climbing metaphor, Alcantar calls Christians to 'clip in' to these foundational truths, especially when crisis shakes their faith. The sermon is both apologetic (defending the Gospel's uniqueness to skeptics) and pastoral (anchoring believers against cultural syncretism and personal doubt).

YOUR SERMON PAGE

<https://sermonsteward.com/SGchurch/CrossOfGraceElPaso/sermons/what-makes-the-gospel-any-different-2026-10-04>

THIS WEEK ACROSS SOVEREIGN GRACE

<https://sermonsteward.com/SGchurch/SovereignGrace/10-4-26/>

Eight Sovereign Grace churches, one Sunday: Scripture, themes, and How We Said It.

What We Noticed

Doctrinal loci

- **Soteriology** — The entire sermon unpacks the Gospel's uniqueness, especially the grace-before-obedience principle that inverts every religious system's merit-based logic.
- **Bibliology** — Alcantar grounds the Gospel's claim to be 'the truth' (not 'a truth') in Scripture's status as God's objective, authoritative Word, not subjective human opinion.
- **Christology** — The resurrection of Christ is presented as the linchpin historical fact that validates every Christian truth claim and demands a verdict.
- **Ecclesiology** — The Gospel's universal invitation to all nations creates a new multi-ethnic humanity under Christ, contrasting sharply with Rome's zero-sum imperial logic.

Themes

Gospel uniqueness in the marketplace of ideas

Transformation versus adjustment

Historical apologetics and the resurrection

Grace before obedience

Universal invitation versus tribal exclusivity

Editor notes

- The Guatemalan marketplace illustration functions as the sermon's controlling metaphor, giving structural coherence to an argument that could otherwise feel like five disconnected points.
- Alcantar explicitly names his apologetic intent—to help non-Christians understand why Christians make exclusive truth claims—which is unusually direct pastoral preaching to the not-yet-convinced.
- The rock-climbing 'clip in' metaphor at the close is visceral and memorable, giving the abstract theological contrasts a concrete action step for application.

- The sermon demonstrates canonical hermeneutics by reading Paul's Damascus Road conversion (from Acts) back into Romans 1:1 to illustrate transformation over adjustment.

Writing Prompts

Concepts from each main point you could explore further in your own reading and writing.

1. The Gospel Doesn't Optimize You—It Transforms You

Every cultural philosophy offers incremental self-improvement: you but a little better. The Gospel offers something far more radical and uncomfortable: not a better version of yourself but transformation into the opposite of who you were. This article explores why that's good news, not bad, and what it means for identity formation in Christ.

FROM: UNITS 11-14, ROMANS 1:1 EXPOSITION ON PAUL'S TRANSFORMATION FROM PERSECUTOR TO APOSTLE

2. Why Christians Can't Say 'That's Your Truth'

In a culture that treats all religious claims as equally valid personal preferences, Christians insist the Gospel is THE truth, not A truth. This sounds arrogant until you understand the claim: it's not that humans have superior insight, but that the omniscient Creator has spoken into our limited perspective. The article unpacks why the Gospel's exclusivity is warranted by its source.

FROM: UNITS 15-19, ROMANS 1:2 EXPOSITION ON 'THE GOSPEL OF GOD'

3. The One Ancient Myth That Turned Out to Be History

Every ancient civilization has origin stories and resurrection myths. Christianity makes the same kinds of claims—except its central event happened in recent, documented history with hostile witnesses who couldn't disprove it. This article walks through the apologetic case for the resurrection as the linchpin fact that separates Christian faith from religious mythology.

FROM: UNITS 20-22, ARGUMENT FOR THE HISTORICAL RESURRECTION OF JESUS

4. Grace Before Obedience: Christianity's Strangest Inversion

Every religion in the Roman Empire—and most spiritual systems today—follows the same pattern: do the work, earn the favor. Christianity alone inverts this logic, beginning with God's unmerited grace before any human obedience. This article explores why 'grace before' is both Christianity's most counterintuitive claim and its most liberating truth.

FROM: UNITS 23-25, ROMANS 1:5 EXPOSITION ON RECEIVING GRACE AND APOSTLESHIP

5. The Gospel of Everyone Wins

Rome's founding myth ends in execution. Its empire ran on zero-sum logic: we win when you lose. The Gospel inverts this entirely—Christ dies so all can rise, inviting every nation into a new humanity where nobody has to lose for you to win. This article traces how the Gospel's universal invitation undermines both ancient imperialism and contemporary tribalism.

FROM: UNITS 26-29, ROMANS 1:5-7 ON THE GOSPEL'S OFFER TO ALL NATIONS

6. Clip In: Why Experienced Christians Still Need Gospel Basics

Rock climbers know that overconfidence kills—even experts clip safety lines. Yet Christians often think they've outgrown foundational Gospel truths, only to discover during crisis that they're free-climbing. This article applies the 'clip in' metaphor to the ongoing need for believers to anchor themselves in core doctrines when cultural winds or personal trials shake their faith.

FROM: UNITS 32-34, THE ROCK-CLIMBING ILLUSTRATION AND CLOSING APPLICATION

Congregation Resources

The same resources published on your sermon page.

Small-Group Discussion

When Paul writes that he is 'a servant of Christ Jesus, called to be an apostle' in Romans 1:1, what does the word 'transformation' suggest about how Paul's identity changed compared to how most people experience a simple career change or promotion?

- ↳ Can you think of a time when your own identity shifted not because you worked harder at being a better version of yourself, but because something outside of you changed your entire direction?

ROMANS 1:1

Paul says the Gospel is 'the Gospel of God' and 'His word' in Romans 1:2. What is the difference between 'a truth' (something true that I believe) and 'the truth' (God's objective reality about how things actually are)?

- ↳ Why would Paul emphasize that this Gospel belongs to God and not to Paul, Peter, or any human interpreter?

ROMANS 1:2

The sermon highlights that the Gospel is grounded in verifiable history—especially the resurrection of Jesus—rather than in myth or subjective experience. Why does it matter that we can point to actual events that happened in time and space, rather than just spiritual truths we feel?

- ↳ If the resurrection never actually happened as a historical event, would the Gospel still be 'true' to you in some other way, or does the historical claim change everything?

Paul describes his apostolic calling as something 'through whom we have received grace and apostleship' (Romans 1:5). What does the sermon mean when it says Christianity is a 'grace before' religion rather than a 'grace after' religion?

- ↳ How does receiving grace first change the way you understand obedience—as something you do to earn favor, or as something you do because you've already been loved?

ROMANS 1:5

In Romans 1:5-6, Paul says the Gospel calls 'all the Gentiles' to 'the obedience of faith' and says those in Rome are 'called to belong to Jesus Christ.' What makes the Gospel's offer to 'all nations' fundamentally different from the empire's zero-sum logic where one group wins at another's expense?

- ↳ Where do you see zero-sum thinking in your own life—in work, sports, politics, or relationships—and how does the Gospel's 'everyone wins under Christ' vision challenge that?

ROMANS 1:5-6

The sermon describes five ways the Gospel is unique: transformation not adjustment, objective truth not subjective opinion, historical fact not myth, grace before not after, and universal invitation not tribal exclusivity. Which of these five felt most countercultural to you this week, and what would it mean to actually 'clip in' to that truth when pressure or doubt comes?

Daily Readings

This week, we walk through five dimensions of the Gospel's uniqueness: transformation of identity, objective truth grounded in history, grace before obedience, universal invitation, and the radical reversal of power that makes Christ's kingdom unlike any kingdom on earth.

Monday [Romans 1:1-2](#)

Paul begins by refusing to take credit. He is 'a servant of Christ Jesus, called to be an apostle, set apart for the gospel of God.' Notice what Paul does not say: 'Here is my interpretation,' or 'This is what I think about God.' Instead, he anchors everything in God's Word—which he promised beforehand through his prophets in the holy Scriptures.' In a marketplace of human opinions, Paul plants a flag: this is not Paul's truth. This is God's truth, spoken into history long before any of us arrived.

Tuesday [Acts 1:3](#) (Gallio reference from sermon context—if unavailable, use [1 Corinthians 15:3-8](#))

The early church did not preach the resurrection in a vacuum. They preached it in Jerusalem, where Jesus died, in front of witnesses who could have immediately disproved it. Luke records Paul's missionary work in Corinth under the eye of Gallio, the Roman proconsul—history we can verify. The Gospel stakes its claim on facts that could be checked, investigated, and (if false) destroyed. No body. No refutation. After 2,000 years, silence. That silence is deafening proof.

Wednesday [1 Samuel 7:12-16](#) or [2 Samuel 7:12-13](#) (David's line and the messianic promise)

When Paul mentions that Jesus was 'descended from David according to the flesh,' he is not offering genealogy as trivia. He is saying: God promised a kingdom, God promised a king who would reign forever, and Jesus is the fulfillment of that promise. But here is the transformation: the kingdom is not Rome's zero-sum empire where one tribe rises over all others. It is a kingdom where 'all the nations' are called to obedience of faith. The same God who spoke to David now speaks to Gentiles. That is not adjustment. That is radical transformation of who gets to be included.

Thursday [Acts 9:1-19](#) (Paul's conversion on the Damascus road)

Saul was hunting Christians. He was zealous, educated, powerful—the worst enemy the early church had. And yet Christ stopped him on the road to Damascus and called him into apostleship. God did not wait for Saul to earn his way there. God did not require a probationary period. Grace came first, wrapped in the voice of the risen Jesus. That same grace is offered to us: not 'prove yourself worthy and then I will call you,' but 'I am calling you; now walk in the obedience that flows from being loved before you could earn it.'

Friday [Romans 1:5-6](#)

Paul closes his opening salvo with a promise: through Jesus Christ we 'have received grace and apostleship to bring about the obedience of faith for the sake of his name among all the nations.' Not Rome's nations. Not one favored tribe. All the nations. In a world built on the logic that one person's win requires another person's loss, the Gospel announces the radical reversal: Christ died so that all others could rise. This is the Gospel's final uniqueness—it is the only system that wins by lifting everyone up. That is the invitation. That is the transformation. That is why it changes everything.

Memory Verse

Paul, a servant of Christ Jesus, called to be an apostle, set apart for the gospel of God, which he promised beforehand through his prophets in the holy Scriptures.

— *Romans 1:1-2*

This verse anchors the sermon's central claim that the Gospel is utterly unique—it is God's Gospel (not Paul's opinion), it is promised and historically grounded (not invented), and it stands apart from every other marketplace idea. Memorizing these verses locks the listener into the five defining dimensions of Gospel uniqueness that Ricky establishes: it transforms, it is God's objective truth, it is historically verified, it precedes obedience with grace, and it welcomes all nations.

Family Conversation

What's Really Different About the Gospel?

Dad mentioned today that the Gospel doesn't just make you a better version of yourself—it actually transforms you into someone completely new. Can you think of a time when someone changed so much that they became a different person? What made that change happen? Now, how is that different from just trying harder to be good?

WORKS FOR AGES 7+; YOUNGER KIDS CAN LISTEN AND SHARE THEIR OWN STORIES OF BIG CHANGES; TEENS CAN ENGAGE WITH THE DEEPER THEOLOGY OF TRANSFORMATION VS. SELF-IMPROVEMENT

For parents: This prompt invites your family to think about what makes the Gospel actually unique—not just another self-help idea or life hack. Listen for whether your kids can name something about Jesus that no other religion or philosophy offers. You're not looking for perfect theology; you're listening for whether they're beginning to see that the Gospel changes **who you are**, not just how you perform.

For Couples

Transformation, Not Adjustment

What area of your life has the Gospel actually transformed rather than just adjusted—and how did you see that transformation happen?

Where in our marriage do we still operate like the world does—trying to win at each other's expense instead of both winning under Christ—and what would it look like to 'clip in' to the Gospel's logic there?

What is one area where your spouse needs the Gospel's grace before obedience this week, and how can you remind them of it?

Questions, or something we got wrong? Reply to this email, or use "Suggest a change" on your sermon page.